

Louis hung his head. At the same time the officer could see the eyes of Marie de Mancini shine in the sun with the brilliancy of a dagger starting from its sheath. 'And you have done nothing in favour of our love?' asked the girl, after a silence of a moment.

'Ah! mademoiselle, how could you believe that? I threw myself at the feet of my mother; I begged her, I implored her; I told her all my hopes of happiness were in you; I even threatened—'

'Well?' asked Marie, eagerly.

'Well, the queen-mother wrote to the court of Rome, and received as answer, that a marriage between us would have no validity, and would be dissolved by the holy father. At length, finding there was no hope for us, I requested to have my marriage with the infanta at least delayed.'

'And yet that does not prevent your being on the road to meet her?'

'How can I help it? To my prayers, to my supplications, to my tears, I received no answer but reasons of state.'

'Well, well?'

'Well, what is to be done, mademoiselle, when so many wills are leagued against me?'

It was now Marie's turn to hang her head. 'Then I must bid you adieu forever,' said she. 'You know that I am being exiled; you know that I am going to be buried alive; you know still more that they want to marry me off, too.'

Louis became very pale, and placed his hand upon his heart.

'If I had thought that my life only had been at stake, I have been so persecuted that I might have yielded; but I thought yours was concerned, my dear sire, and I stood out for the sake of preserving your happiness.'

'Oh, yes! my happiness, my treasure!' murmured the king, more gallantly than passionately, perhaps.

'The cardinal might have yielded,' said Marie, 'if you had addressed yourself to him, if you had pressed him. For the cardinal to call the king of France his nephew! do you not perceive, sire? He would have made war even for that honour; the cardinal, assured of governing alone, under the double pretext of having brought up the king and given his niece to him in marriage—the cardinal would have fought all antagonists, overcome all obstacles. Oh, sire! I can answer for that. I am a woman, and I see clearly into everything where love is concerned.'

These words produced a strange effect upon the king. Instead of heightening his passion, they cooled it. He stopped, and said hastily,—
'What is to be said, mademoiselle? Everything has failed.'

'Except your will, I trust, my dear sire?'

'Alas!' said the king, colouring, 'have I a will?'

'Oh!' said Mademoiselle de Mancini mournfully, wounded by that expression.

'The king has no will but that which policy dictates, but that which reasons of state impose upon him.'

'Oh! it is because you have no love,' cried Mary; 'if you loved, sire, you would have a will.'

On pronouncing these words, Mary raised her eyes to her lover, whom she saw more pale and more cast down than an exile who is about to quit his native land forever. 'Accuse me,' murmured the king, 'but do not say I do not love you.'

A long silence followed these words, which the young king had pronounced with a perfectly true and profound feeling. 'I am unable to think that to-morrow, and after to-morrow, I shall see you no more; I cannot think that I am going to end my sad days at a distance from Paris; that the lips of an old man, of an unknown, should touch that hand which you hold within yours; no, in truth, I cannot think of all that, my dear sire, without having my poor heart burst with despair.'

And Marie de Mancini did shed floods of tears. On his part, the king, much affected, carried his handkerchief to his mouth, and stifled a sob.

'See,' said she, 'the carriages have stopped, my sister waits for me, the time is come; what you are about to decide upon will be decided for life. Oh, sire! you are willing, then, that I should lose you? You are willing, then, Louis, that she to whom you have said "I love you," should belong to another than to her king, to her master, to her lover? Oh! courage, Louis! courage! One word, a single word! Say "I will!" and all my life is enchained to yours, and all my heart is yours forever.'

The king made no reply. Mary then looked at him as Dido looked at Aeneas in the Elysian fields, fierce and disdainful.

'Farewell, then,' said she; 'farewell life! love! heaven!'

And she took a step away. The king detained her, seizing her hand, which he pressed to his lips, and despair prevailing over the resolution he

appeared to have inwardly formed, he let fall upon that beautiful hand a burning tear of regret, which made Mary start, so really had that tear burnt her. She saw the humid eyes of the king, his pale brow, his convulsed lips, and cried, with an accent that cannot be described,—

‘Oh, sire! you are a king, you weep, and yet I depart!’

As his sole reply, the king hid his face in his handkerchief. The officer uttered something so like a roar that it frightened the horses. Mademoiselle de Mancini, quite indignant, quitted the king’s arm, hastily entered the carriage, crying to the coachman, ‘Go on, go on, and quick!’

The coachman obeyed, flogging his mules, and the heavy carriage rocked upon its creaking axle, whilst the king of France, alone, cast down, annihilated, did not dare to look either behind or before him.

‘Ah, my dear sire!’ and the tears gushed from her eyes.

The coachman stopped his team; the women rose in confusion from the back of the carriage, and the second lady made a slight curtsy, terminated by the most ironical smile that jealousy ever imparted to the lips of woman.

‘Marie, dear Marie,’ cried the king, taking the hand of the black-eyed lady in both his. And opening the heavy door himself, he drew her out of the carriage with so much ardour, that she was in his arms before she touched the ground. The lieutenant, posted on the other side of the carriage, saw and heard all without being observed.

The king offered his arm to Mademoiselle de Mancini, and made a sign to the coachman and lackeys to proceed. It was nearly six o’clock; the road was fresh and pleasant; tall trees with their foliage still inclosed in the golden down of their buds, let the dew of morning filter from their trembling branches, like liquid diamonds; the grass was bursting at the foot of the hedges; the swallows having returned only a few days since, described their graceful curves between the heavens and the water; a breeze, laden with the perfumes of the blossoming woods, sighed along the road, and wrinkled the surface of the waters of the river; all these beauties of the day, all these perfumes of the plants, all these aspirations of the earth towards heaven, intoxicated the two lovers, walking side by side, leaning upon each other, eyes fixed upon eyes, hand clasping hand, and who, lingering as by a common desire, did not dare to speak, they had so much to say.

The officer saw that the king’s horse, in wandering this way and that, annoyed Mademoiselle de Mancini. He took advantage of the pretext of securing the horse to draw near them, and dismounting, walked between the two horses he led; he did not lose a single word or gesture of the lovers. It was Mademoiselle de Mancini who at length began.

‘Ah, my dear sire!’ said she, ‘you do not abandon me, then?’

‘No, Marie,’ replied the king; ‘you see I do not.’

‘I had so often been told, though, that as soon as we should be separated you would no longer think of me.’

‘Dear Marie, is it then to-day only that you have discovered we are surrounded by people interested in deceiving us?’

‘But then, sire, this journey, this alliance with Spain? They are going to marry you off!’

'A carriage in which you will see two ladies, and probably their attendants likewise.'

'Sire, I should not wish to make a mistake; is there no other sign by which I may know this carriage?'

'It will bear, in all probability, the arms of monsieur le cardinal.'

'That is sufficient, sire,' replied the officer, fully instructed in the object of his search. He put his horse to the trot, and rode sharply on in the direction pointed out by the king. But he had scarcely gone five hundred paces when he saw four mules, and then a carriage, loom up from behind a little hill. Behind this carriage came another. It required only one glance to assure him that these were the equipages he was in search of; he therefore turned his bridle, and rode back to the king.

'Sire,' said he, 'here are the carriages. The first, as you said, contains two ladies with their femmes de chambre; the second contains the footmen, provisions, and necessities.'

'That is well,' replied the king in an agitated voice. 'Please to go and tell those ladies that a cavalier of the court wishes to pay his respects to them alone.'

The officer set off at a gallop. 'Mordieux!' said he, as he rode on, 'here is a new and honourable employment, I hope! I complained of being nobody. I am the king's confidant: that is enough to make a musketeer burst with pride.'

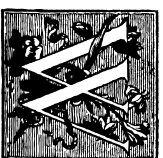
He approached the carriage, and delivered his message gallantly and intelligently. There were two ladies in the carriage: one of great beauty, although rather thin; the other less favoured by nature, but lively, graceful, and uniting in the delicate lines of her brow all the signs of a strong will. Her eyes, animated and piercing, in particular, spoke more eloquently than all the amorous phrases in fashion in those days of gallantry. It was to her D'Artagnan addressed himself, without fear of being mistaken, although the other was, as we have said, the more handsome of the two.

'Madame,' said he, 'I am the lieutenant of the musketeers, and there is on the road a horseman who awaits you, and is desirous of paying his respects to you.'

At these words, the effect of which he watched closely, the lady with the black eyes uttered a cry of joy, leant out of the carriage window, and seeing the cavalier approaching, held out her arms, exclaiming:

Chapter XIV

In Which the King and the Lieutenant Each Give Proofs of Memory



WHEN the king, like all the people in the world who are in love, had long and attentively watched disappear in the distance the carriage which bore away his mistress; when he had turned and turned again a hundred times to the same side and had at length succeeded in somewhat calming the agitation of his heart and thoughts, he recollected that he was not alone. The officer still held the horse by the bridle, and had not lost all hope of seeing the king recover his resolution. He had still the resource of mounting and riding after the carriage; they would have lost nothing by waiting a little. But the imagination of the lieutenant of the musketeers was too rich and too brilliant; it left far behind it that of the king, who took care not to allow himself to be carried away to such excess. He contented himself with approaching the officer, and in a doleful voice, 'Come,' said he, 'let us be gone; all is ended. To horse!'

The officer imitated this carriage, this slowness, this sadness, and leisurely mounted his horse. The king pushed on sharply, the lieutenant followed him. At the bridge Louis turned around for the last time. The lieutenant, patient as a god who has eternity behind and before him, still hoped for a return of energy. But it was groundless, nothing appeared. Louis gained the street which led to the castle, and entered as seven was striking. When the king had returned, and the musketeer, who saw everything, had seen a corner of the tapestry over the cardinal's win-

dow lifted up, he breathed a profound sigh, like a man unloosed from the tightest bonds, and said in a low voice:

‘Now then, my officer, I hope that it is over.’

The king summoned his gentleman. ‘Please to understand I shall receive nobody before two o’clock,’ said he.

‘Sire,’ replied the gentleman, ‘there is, however, some one who requests admittance.’

‘Who is that?’

‘Your lieutenant of musketeers.’

‘He who accompanied me?’

‘Yes, sire.’

‘Ah,’ said the king, ‘let him come in.’

The officer entered. The king made a sign, and the gentleman and the valet retired. Louis followed them with his eyes until they had shut the door, and when the tapestries had fallen behind them, — ‘You remind me by your presence, monsieur, of something I had forgotten to recommend to you, that is to say, the most absolute discretion.’

‘Oh! sire, why does your majesty give yourself the trouble of making me such a recommendation? It is plain you do not know me.’

‘Yes, monsieur, that is true. I know that you are discreet; but as I had prescribed nothing—’

The officer bowed. ‘Has your majesty nothing else to say to me?’

‘No, monsieur; you may retire.’

‘Shall I obtain permission not to do so till I have spoken to the king, sire?’

‘What do you have to say to me? Explain yourself, monsieur.’

‘Sire, a thing without importance to you, but which interests me greatly. Pardon me, then, for speaking of it. Without urgency, without necessity, I never would have done it, and I would have disappeared, mute and insignificant as I always have been.’

‘How! Disappeared! I do not understand you, monsieur.’

‘Sire, in a word,’ said the officer, ‘I am come to ask for my discharge from your majesty’s service.’

The king made a movement of surprise, but the officer remained as motionless as a statue.

‘Your discharge—yours, monsieur? and for how long a time, I pray?’

Chapter XIII

Mary de Mancini



THE sun had scarcely shed its first beams on the majestic trees of the park and the lofty turrets of the castle, when the young king, who had been awake more than two hours, possessed by the sleeplessness of love, opened his shutters himself, and cast an inquiring look into the courts of the sleeping palace. He saw that it was the hour agreed upon: the great court clock pointed to a quarter past four. He did not disturb his valet de chambre, who was sleeping soundly at some distance; he dressed himself, and the valet, in a great fright, sprang up, thinking he had been deficient in his duty; but the king sent him back again, commanding him to preserve the most absolute silence. He then descended the little staircase, went out at a lateral door, and perceived at the end of the wall a mounted horseman, holding another horse by the bridle. This horseman could not be recognized in his cloak and slouched hat. As to the horse, saddled like that of a rich citizen, it offered nothing remarkable to the most experienced eye. Louis took the bridle: the officer held the stirrup without dismounting, and asked his majesty’s orders in a low voice.

‘Follow me,’ replied the king.

The officer put his horse to the trot, behind that of his master, and they descended the hill towards the bridge. When they reached the other side of the Loire,—

‘Monsieur,’ said the king, ‘you will please to ride on till you see a carriage coming; then return and inform me. I will wait here.’

‘Will your majesty deign to give me some description of the carriage I am charged to discover?’

‘Why, forever, sire.’

‘What, you are desirous of quitting my service, monsieur?’ said Louis, with an expression that revealed something more than surprise.

‘Sire, I regret to say that I am.’

‘Impossible!’

‘It is so, however, sire. I am getting old; I have worn harness now thirty-five years; my poor shoulders are tired; I feel that I must give place to the young. I don’t belong to this age; I have still one foot in the old one; it results that everything is strange in my eyes, everything astonishes and bewilders me. In short, I have the honour to ask your majesty for my discharge.’

‘Monsieur,’ said the king, looking at the officer, who wore his uniform with an ease that would have caused envy in a young man, ‘you are stronger and more vigorous than I am.’

‘Oh!’ replied the officer, with an air of false modesty, ‘your majesty says so because I still have a good eye and a tolerably firm foot—because I can still ride a horse, and my moustache is black; but, sire, vanity of vanities all that—illusions all that—appearance, smoke, sire! I have still a youthful air, it is true, but I feel old, and within six months I am certain I shall be broken down, gouty, impotent. Therefore, then, sire—’

‘Monsieur,’ interrupted the king, ‘remember your words of yesterday. You said to me in this very place where you now are, that you were endowed with the best health of any man in France; that fatigue was unknown to you! that you did not mind spending whole days and nights at your post. Did you tell me that, monsieur, or not? Try and recall, monsieur.’

The officer sighed. ‘Sire,’ said he, ‘old age is boastful; and it is pardonable for old men to praise themselves when others no longer do it. It is very possible I said that; but the fact is, sire, I am very much fatigued, an request permission to retire.’

‘Monsieur,’ said the king, advancing towards the officer with a gesture full of majesty, ‘you are not assigning me the true reason. You wish to quit my service, it may be true, but you disguise from me the motive of your retreat.’

‘Sire, believe that—’

‘I believe what I see, monsieur; I see a vigorous, energetic man, full of presence of mind, the best soldier in France, perhaps; and this personage cannot persuade me the least in the world that he stands in need of rest.’

‘Ah! sire,’ said the lieutenant, with bitterness, ‘what praise! Indeed, your majesty confounds me! Energetic, vigorous, brave, intelligent, the best soldier in the army! But, sire, your majesty exaggerates my small portion of merit to such a point, that however good an opinion I may have of myself, I do not recognize myself; in truth I do not. If I were vain enough to believe only half of your majesty’s words, I should consider myself a valuable, indispensable man. I should say that a servant possessed of such brilliant qualities was a treasure beyond all price. Now, sire, I have been all my life—I feel bound to say it—except at the present time, appreciated, in my opinion, much below my value. I therefore repeat, your majesty exaggerates.’

The king knitted his brow, for he saw a bitter railleury beneath the words of the officer. ‘Come, monsieur,’ said he, ‘let us meet the question frankly. Are you dissatisfied with my service, say? No evasions; speak boldly, frankly—I command you to do so.’

The officer, who had been twisting his hat about in his hands, with an embarrassed air, for several minutes, raised his head at these words. ‘Oh! sire,’ said he, ‘that puts me a little more at my ease. To a question put so frankly, I will reply frankly. To tell the truth is a good thing, as much from the pleasure one feels in relieving one’s heart, as on account of the rarity of the fact. I will speak the truth, then, to my king, at the same time imploring him to excuse the frankness of an old soldier.’

Louis looked at his officer with anxiety, which he manifested by the agitation of his gesture. ‘Well, then, speak,’ said he, ‘for I am impatient to hear the truths you have to tell me.’

The officer threw his hat upon a table, and his countenance, always so intelligent and martial, assumed, all at once, a strange character of grandeur and solemnity. ‘Sire,’ said he, ‘I quit the king’s service because I am dissatisfied. The valet, in these times, can approach his master as respectfully as I do, can give him an account of his labour, bring back his tools, return the funds that have been intrusted to him, and say “Master, my day’s work is done. Pay me, if you please, and let us part.”’

‘Monsieur! monsieur!’ exclaimed the king, crimson with rage.

this order—“Monsieur the lieutenant of my musketeers, be on horseback to-morrow at four o’clock in the morning.” Which is as clear as if he had said,—“Monsieur the lieutenant of my musketeers, to-morrow, at four, at the bridge of Blois,—do you understand?” Here is a state secret, then, which I, humble as I am, have in my possession, while it is in action. And how do I get it? Because I have good eyes, as his majesty just now said. They say he loves this little Italian doll furiously. They say he threw himself at his mother’s feet, to beg her to allow him to marry her. They say the queen went so far as to consult the court of Rome, whether such a marriage, contracted against her will, would be valid. Oh, if I were but twenty-five! If I had by my side those I no longer have! If I did not despise the whole world most profoundly, I would embroil Mazarin with the queen-mother, France with Spain, and I would make a queen after my own fashion. But let that pass.’ And the lieutenant snapped his fingers in disdain.

‘This miserable Italian—this poor creature—this sordid wretch—who has just refused the king of England a million, would not perhaps give me a thousand pistoles for the news I would carry him. Mordieux! I am falling into second childhood—I am becoming stupid indeed! The idea of Mazarin giving anything! ha! ha! ha!’ and he laughed in a subdued voice.

‘Well, let us go to sleep—let us go to sleep; and the sooner the better. My mind is wearied with my evening’s work, and will see things to-morrow more clearly than to-day.’

And upon this recommendation, made to himself, he folded his cloak around him, looking with contempt upon his royal neighbour. Five minutes after this he was asleep, with his hands clenched and his lips apart, giving escape, not to his secret, but to a sonorous sound, which rose and spread freely beneath the majestic roof of the ante-chamber.

‘No; one of your musketeers’ horses.’

‘Very well, sire. Is that all?’

‘And you will accompany me.’

‘Alone?’

‘Alone.’

‘Shall I come to seek your majesty, or shall I wait?’

‘You will wait for me.’

‘Where, sire?’

‘At the little park-gate.’

The lieutenant bowed, understanding that the king had told him all he had to say. In fact, the king dismissed him with a gracious wave of the hand. The officer left the chamber of the king, and returned to place himself philosophically in his fauteuil, where, far from sleeping, as might have been expected, considering how late it was, he began to reflect more deeply than he had ever reflected before. The result of these reflections was not so melancholy as the preceding ones had been.

‘Come, he has begun,’ said he. ‘Love urges him on, and he goes forward—he goes forward! The king is nobody in his own palace; but the man perhaps may prove to be worth something. Well, we shall see to-morrow morning. Oh! oh!’ cried he, all at once starting up, ‘that is a gigantic idea, mordoux! and perhaps my fortune depends, at least, upon that idea!’ After this exclamation, the officer arose and marched, with his hands in the pockets of his justaucorps, about the immense ante-chamber that served him as an apartment. The wax-light flamed furiously under the effects of a fresh breeze, which strolled in through the chinks of the door and the window, and cut the salle diagonally. It threw out a reddish, unequal light, sometimes brilliant, sometimes dull, and the tall shadow of the lieutenant was seen marching on the wall, in profile, like a figure by Callot, with his long sword and feathered hat.

‘Certainly!’ said he, ‘I am mistaken if Mazarin is not laying a snare for this amorous boy. Mazarin, this evening, gave an address, and made an appointment as complacently as M. Daangeau himself could have done—I heard him, and I know the meaning of his words. “To-morrow morning,” said he, “they will pass opposite the bridge of Biois.” Mordoux! that is clear enough, and particularly for a lover. That is the cause of this embarrassment; that is the cause of this hesitation; that is the cause of

‘Ah! sire,’ replied the officer, bending his knee for a moment, ‘never was servant more respectful than I am before your majesty; only you commanded me to tell the truth. Now I have begun to tell it, it must come out, even if you command me to hold my tongue.’

There was so much resolution expressed in the deep-sunk muscles of the officer’s countenance, that Louis XIV had no occasion to tell him to continue; he continued, therefore, whilst the king looked at him with a curiosity mingled with admiration.

‘Sire, I have, as I have said, now served the house of France thirty-five years; few people have worn out so many swords in that service as I have, and the swords I speak of were good swords, too, sire. I was a boy, ignorant of everything except courage, when the king your father guessed that there was a man in me. I was a man, sire, when the Cardinal de Richelieu, who was a judge of manhood, discovered an enemy in me. Sire, the history of that enmity between the ant and the lion may be read from the first to the last line, in the secret archives of your family. If ever you feel an inclination to know it, do so, sire; the history is worth the trouble—it is I who tell you so. You will there read that the lion, fatigued, harassed, out of breath, at length cried for quarter, and the justice must be rendered him to say, that he gave as much as he required. Oh! those were glorious times, sire, strewn over with battles like one of Tasso’s or Ariosto’s epics. The wonders of those times, to which the people of ours would refuse belief, were every-day occurrences. For five years together, I was a hero every day; at least, so I was told by persons of judgment; and that is a long period for heroism, trust me, sire, a period of five years. Nevertheless, I have faith in what these people told me, for the were good judges. They were named M. de Richelieu, M. de Buckingham, M. de Beaufort, M. de Retz, a mighty genius himself in street warfare,—in short, the king, Louis XIII, and even the queen, your noble mother, who one day condescended to say, “Thank you. I don’t know what service I had had the good fortune to render her. Pardon me, sire, for speaking so boldly; but what I relate to you, as I have already had the honour to tell your majesty, is history.” The king bit his lips, and threw himself violently on a chair.

‘I appear importunate to your majesty,’ said the lieutenant. ‘Eh! sire, that is the fate of truth; she is a stern companion; she bristles all over with

steel, she wounds those whom she attacks, and sometimes him who speaks her.’

‘No, monsieur,’ replied the king: ‘I bade you speak—speak then.’

‘After the service of the king and the cardinal, came the service of the regency, sire; I fought pretty well in the Fronde—much less, though, than the first time. The men began to diminish in stature. I have, nevertheless, led your majesty’s musketeers on some perilous occasions, which stand upon the orders of the day of the company. Mine was a beautiful luck at that time. I was the favourite of M. de Mazarin. Lieutenant here! lieutenant there! lieutenant to the right! lieutenant to the left! There was not a buffet dealt in France, of which your humble servant did not have the dealing; but soon France was not enough. The cardinal sent me to England on Cromwell’s account; another gentleman who was not over gentle, I assure you, sire. I had the honour of knowing him, and I was well able to appreciate him. A great deal was promised me on account of that mission. So, as I did much more than I had been bidden to do, I was generously paid, for I was at length appointed captain of the musketeers; that is to say, the most envied position in court, which takes precedence over the marshals of France, and justly; for who says captain of the musketeers says the flower of chivalry and king of the brave.’

‘Captain, monsieur!’ interrupted the king; ‘you make a mistake. Lieutenant, you mean.’

‘Not at all, sire—I make no mistake; your majesty may rely upon me in that respect. Monsieur le cardinal gave me the commission himself.’

‘Well!’

‘But M. de Mazarin, as you know better than anybody, does not often give, and sometimes takes back what he has given; he took it back again as soon as peace was made and he was no longer in want of me. Certainly I was not worthy to replace M. de Treville, of illustrious memory; but they had promised me, and they had given me; they ought to have stopped there.’

‘Is that what dissatisfies you monsieur? Well, I shall make inquiries. I love justice; and your claim, though made in military fashion, does not displease me.’

‘Oh, sire!’ said the officer, ‘your majesty has ill understood me; I no longer claim anything now.’

opportunity. Now, this evening, they saw that your majesty coloured with endeavouring to conceal the inclination to yawn, that your majesty looked with eloquent supplications, first to his eminence, and then at her majesty, the queen-mother, and at length to the entrance door, and they so thoroughly remarked all I have said, that they saw your majesty’s lips articulate these words: “Who will get me out of this?”

‘Monsieur!’

‘Or something to this effect, sire—“My musketeers!” I could then no longer hesitate. That look was for me. I cried out instantly, “His majesty’s musketeers!” And, besides, that was shown to be true, sire, not only by your majesty’s not saying I was wrong, but proving I was right by going out at once.’

The king turned away to smile; then, after a few seconds, he again fixed his limpid eye upon that countenance, so intelligent, so bold, and so firm, that it might have been said to be the proud and energetic profile of the eagle facing the sun. ‘That is all very well,’ said he, after a short silence, during which he endeavoured, in vain, to make his officer lower his eyes.

But seeing the king said no more, the latter pirouetted on his heels, and took three steps towards the door, muttering, ‘He will not speak! Mordieux! he will not speak!’

‘Thank you, monsieur,’ said the king at last.

‘Humph!’ continued the lieutenant; ‘there was only wanting that. Blamed for having been less of a fool than another might have been.’ And he went to the door, allowing his spurs to jingle in true military style. But when he was on the threshold, feeling the king’s desire drew him back, he returned.

‘Has your majesty told me all?’ asked he, in a tone we cannot describe, but which, without appearing to solicit the royal confidence, contained so much persuasive frankness, that the king immediately replied:

‘Yes; but draw near, monsieur.’

‘Now then,’ murmured the officer, ‘he is coming to it at last.’

‘Listen to me.’

‘I shall not lose a word, sire.’

‘You will mount on horseback to-morrow, at about half-past four in the morning, and you will have a horse saddled for me.’

‘From your majesty’s stables?’

not be there. My duty and the peace of my conscience before everything, sire.’

‘But such duty will kill you, monsieur.’

‘Eh! sire, I have performed it for thirty years, and in all France and Navarre there is not a man in better health than I am. Moreover, I entreat you, sire, not to trouble yourself about me. That would appear very strange to me, seeing that I am not accustomed to it.’

The king cut short the conversation by a fresh question. ‘Shall you be here, then, to-morrow morning?’

‘As at present? yes, sire.’

The king walked several times up and down his chamber; it was very plain that he burned with a desire to speak, but that he was restrained by some fear or other. The lieutenant, standing motionless, hat in hand, watched him making these evolutions, and, whilst looking at him, grumbled to himself, biting his moustache:

‘He has not half a crown worth of resolution! Parole d’honneur! I would lay a wager he does not speak at all!’

The king continued to walk about, casting from time to time a side glance at the lieutenant. ‘He is the very image of his father,’ continued the latter, in a secret soliloquy, ‘he is at once proud, avaricious, and timid. The devil take his master, say I!’

The king stopped. ‘Lieutenant,’ said he.

‘I am here, sire.’

‘Why did you cry out this evening, down below in the salons—“The king’s service! His majesty’s musketeers!”’

‘Because you gave me the order, sire.’

‘I? Yourself?’

‘Indeed, I did not say a word, monsieur.’

‘Sire, an order is given by a sign, by a gesture, by a glance, as intelligibly as freely, and as clearly as by word of mouth. A servant who has nothing but ears is not half a good servant.’

‘Your eyes are very penetrating, then, monsieur.’

‘How is that, sire?’

‘Because they see what is not.’

‘My eyes are good, though, sire, although they have served their master long and much: when they have anything to see, they seldom miss the

‘Excess of delicacy, monsieur; but I will keep my eye upon your affairs, and later—’

‘Oh, sire! what a word!—later! Thirty years have I lived upon that promising word, which has been pronounced by so many great personages, and which your mouth has, in its turn, just pronounced. Later—that is how I have received a score of wounds, and how I have reached fifty-four years of age without ever having had a louis in my purse, and without ever having met with a protector on my way,—I who have protected so many people! So I change my formula, sire; and when any one says to me “Later,” I reply “Now.” It is rest that I solicit, sire. That may be easily granted me. That will cost nobody anything.’

‘I did not look for this language, monsieur, particularly from a man who has always lived among the great. You forget you are speaking to the king, to a gentleman who is, I suppose, as of good a house as yourself; and when I say later, I mean a certainty.’

‘I do not at all doubt it, sire; but this is the end of the terrible truth I had to tell you. If I were to see upon that table a marshal’s stick, the sword of constable, the crown of Poland, instead of later, I swear to you, sire, that I should still say Now! Oh, excuse me, sire! I am from the country of your grandfather, Henry IV. I do not speak often: but when I do speak, I speak all.’

‘The future of my reign has little temptation for you, monsieur, it appears,’ said Louis, haughtily.

‘Forgetfulness, forgetfulness everywhere!’ cried the officer, with a noble air; ‘the master has forgotten the servant, so the servant is reduced to forget his master. I live in unfortunate times, sire. I see youth full of discouragement and fear, I see it timid and despoiled, when it ought to be rich and powerful. I yesterday evening, for example, open the door to a king of England, whose father, humble as I am, I was near saving, if God had not been against me—God, who inspired His elect, Cromwell! I open, I said, the door, that is to say, the palace of one brother to another brother, and I see—stop, sire, that is a load on my heart—I see the minister of that king drive away the proscribed prince, and humiliate his master by condemning to want another king, his equal. Then I see my prince, who is young, handsome and brave, who has courage in his heart and lightning in his eye,—I see him tremble before a priest, who laughs at him behind

the curtain of his alcove, where he digests all the gold of France, which he afterwards stuffs into secret coffers. Yes—I understand your looks, sire. I am bold to madness; but what is to be said? I am an old man, and I tell you here, sire, to you, my king, things which I would cram down the throat of any one who should dare to pronounce them before me. You have commanded me, to pour out the bottom of my heart before you, sire, and I cast at the feet of your majesty the pent-up indignation of thirty years, as I would pour out all my blood, if your majesty commanded me to do so.'

The king, without speaking a word, wiped the drops of cold and abundant perspiration which trickled from his temples. The moment of silence which followed this vehement outbreak represented for him who had spoken, and for him who had listened, ages of suffering.

'Monsieur,' said the king at length, 'you spoke the word forgetfulness. I have heard nothing but that word; I will reply, then, to it alone. Others have perhaps been able to forget, but I have not, and the proof is, that I remember that one day of riot, that one day when the furious people, raging and roaring as the sea, invaded the royal palace; that one day when I feigned sleep in my bed, one man alone, naked sword in hand, concealed behind my curtain, watched over my life, ready to risk his own for me, as he had before risked it twenty times for the lives of my family. Was not the gentleman, whose name I then demanded, called M. d'Artagnan? say, monsieur.'

'Your majesty has a good memory,' replied the officer, coldly.

'You see, then,' continued the king, 'if I have such remembrances of my childhood, what an amount I may gather in the age of reason.'

'Your majesty has been richly endowed by God,' said the officer, in the same tone.

'Come, Monsieur d'Artagnan,' continued Louis, with feverish agitation, 'ought you not to be patient as I am? Ought you not to do as I do? Come!'

'And what do you do, sire?'

'I wait.'

'Your majesty may do so, because you are young; but I, sire, have not time to wait; old age is at my door, and death is behind it, looking into the very depths of my house. Your majesty is beginning life, its future is

Chapter XII

The King and the Lieutenant



As soon as the king saw the officer enter, he dismissed his valet de chambre and his gentleman.

'Who is on duty to-morrow, monsieur?' asked he.

The lieutenant bowed his head with military politeness, and replied, 'I am, sire.'

'What! still you?'

'Always I, sire.'

'How can that be, monsieur?'

'Sire, when travelling, the musketeers supply all the posts of your majesty's household; that is to say, yours, her majesty the queen's, and monsieur le cardinal's, the latter of whom borrows of the king the best part, or rather the numerous part, of the royal guard.'

'But in the interims?'

'There are no interims, sire, but for twenty or thirty men who rest out of a hundred and twenty. At the Louvre it is very different, and if I were at the Louvre I should rely upon my brigadier; but, when travelling, sire, no one knows what may happen, and I prefer doing my duty myself.'

'Then you are on guard every day?'

'And every night. Yes, sire.'

'Monsieur, I cannot allow that—I will have you rest.'

'That is very kind, sire; but I will not.'

'What do you say?' said the king, who did not at first comprehend the full meaning of this reply.

'I say, sire, that I will not expose myself to the chance of a fault. If the devil had a trick to play on me, you understand, sire, as he knows the man with whom he has to deal, he would chose the moment when I should